

Golden Temple of Amritsar

The chief house of worship for Sikhs, lavishly decorated with gold and surrounded by a shimmering pool of “holy nectar”

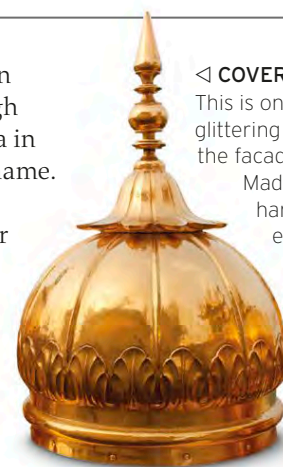
The Golden Temple (or *Harmandir Sahib*, meaning “temple of god”) is located in northern India’s Punjab, where the Sikh religion originated. The construction work was carried out by Guru Arjan, the fifth Sikh guru, and the *Gurdwara* (the Sikh name for a place of assembly and worship) was completed by 1604.

Extravagance and humility

Nothing remains of the early versions of the temple because the shrine was repeatedly attacked by hostile Muslim armies. The present building dates mainly from the 18th century, when it was rebuilt. However,

its most sumptuous adornments were added in the following century by Maharaja Ranjit Singh (r.1792–1804), who covered the entire roof area in gold foil, giving the temple its “Golden” nickname. The most striking feature of the interior is the ornate, jeweled canopy in the main hall, under which the *Guru Granth Sahib*—the Sikhs’ sacred text—is placed on display.

In keeping with the Sikhs’ sense of humility, the temple authorities claim to run the largest *langar* (community kitchen) in the world, offering free food to up to 100,000 people of all faiths every day.



◀ COVERED IN GOLD

This is one of the several glittering turrets that adorn the facade of the shrine.

Made of pure gold, their harmonious design echoes the shape of the temple’s dome.

